Meerut in March 2019.[35] This is partly why Modi refused to suspend the project in spite of the pandemic-induced economic crisis—a demand made by Congress President Sonia Gandhi, among others, as a cost-saving measure.[36] Modi tellingly chose the inauguration ceremony of new office complexes for 7,000 defence officers on Delhi's Kasturba Gandhi Marg and Africa Avenue to personally respond in public for the first time to criticism of the Central Vista project. The officers deputed to these new complexes on Kasturba Gandhi Marg and Africa Avenue had earlier been working out of colonial-era hutments. They were now relocating to spanking new buildings. Addressing them and an audience consisting of the top brass from the Army, Navy and Air Force, Modi said, 'Those people who are after the Central Vista project with a stick, with great cleverness they kept totally quiet on the fact that this is also a part of the Central Vista, that a facility where more than 7,000 armed forces officers work is being developed. Because they knew that their intent of spreading doubts and lies, their loose talk won't work as soon as this fact came out. Today the country is watching what we are doing behind the Central Vista. Now see, these modern offices built on K.G. Marg and Africa Avenue will greatly help in effectively managing all work linked to national security. This is a big and important step towards the construction of a modern defence enclave in the capital.'[37]

The BJP: Challenges and Prospects from 2021 Onwards

'The revolution is coming,' a prominent businessman said to me. 'The BJP will soon fall.' This is a deeply held view among many of my friends who dislike the BJP's cultural politics. They hold that it somehow became the dominant Indian party through a sleight of hand by appealing to Hindutva sentiments. Ergo, when emotions calm, the party will collapse. Are they right? Or is this the vain hope of out-of-touch liberals who feel marginalised in a country that has changed enormously since the BJP came to power?

Admittedly, the BJP was at the peak of its political fortunes in 2020 and is therefore facing the challenge of staying there. It comes